KIRTAN KIT

Booklet and 2 Discs

CHANTING TOOLS TO *Awaken the SOUL*

Disc One The Rhythm of Devotion

1. Râma Bolo *Krishna Das*

2. Sri Râdhikâ-Stava *Agni Dev*

3. Ohe! Vaishnava Thâkura *Gaura Vani*

4. Namah Shivaya *Krishna Das*

5. The Glories of Sri Râdhâ *Karnamrita*

6. Maha Mantra *Agni Dev*

7. Prayers of Draupadi *Karnamrita*

"[Kirtan] cleanses the heart of all the dust accumulated for years; it extinguishes the fire of conditional life, of repeated birth and death... It increases the ocean of transcendental bliss, and it enables us to fully taste the nectar for which we are always anxious."

— Shiksastaka

"The Holy Name is more compassionate than the Lord of the Name himself. If one takes shelter of the Name, then it unravels all philosophical complexities."

— Saraswati Thakur

"Repeat the name of Amida Buddha with all your heart. Whether walking or standing, sitting or lying down, never cease the practice of it even for a moment."

— Zendo, the great Chinese advocate of the Pure Land Buddhist doctrine

"The name of the Lord is a strong tower: the righteous runneth into it and are safe."

— Old Testament

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Chapter 1

A Beginner's Guide to Kirtan

What is *Kirtan?*

Kirtan is a musical chanting practice that originated in ancient India. It consists of the singing of mantras in a call and response arrangement, accompanied by the playing of instruments, clapping of hands, and sometimes dancing.

While kirtan is a musical expression, one's participation is not dependent on musical or vocal skill. Sing from your heart as an offering to the Divine, with no self-consciousness of your singing tone. Adding a tambourine or shakers is an easy way to enhance your contribution. Keep your awareness on hearing as much as you do on participating; this hearing provides the real benefits to one's consciousness.

The kirtan leader, also known as the kirtaniya, is often chosen for his or her devotional sincerity and ability to lead the chanting meditation of the whole group. The kirtaniya often begins the kirtan in a slow tempo with a mantra or phrase that is then repeated by everyone else. Some kirtans are simple mantra phrases that are repeated with

slight variations, while others are longer devotional poems of prayer and glorification of the Divine. As the kirtan progresses, the tempo will often build and the leader will sometimes add variations or new mantras as the group becomes familiar with the words and absorbed in the meditation.

Clapping in kirtan is a wonderful way to further engage the body in this meditation, and it is said to have its own purifying effects. Clapping also makes kirtan possible at any time and any place, since no special instruments are required. It is also a great way to participate if you are unfamiliar with the words.

Kirtan as *Meditation*

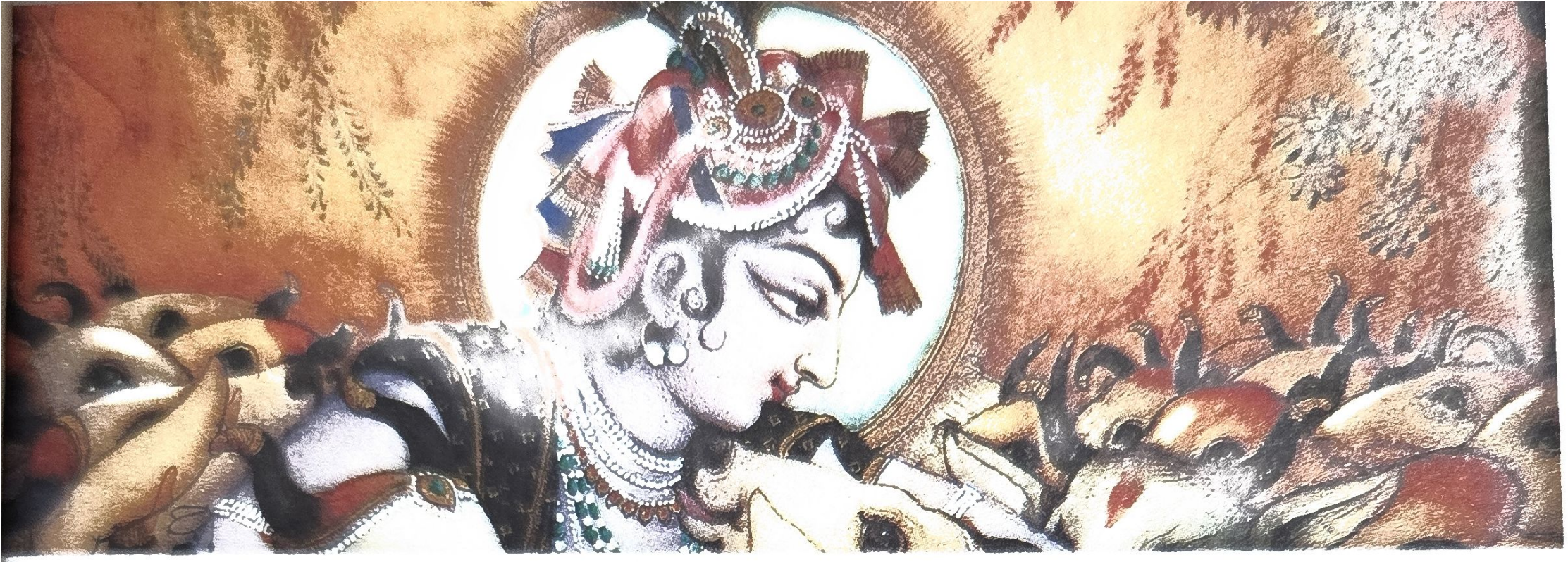
Mantra meditation takes several different forms. Mantras can be recited in a personal meditation with prayer beads, known as japa in India. The process of congregational chanting is kirtan. "Kirtan is more of a supercharged meditation process, where in addition to hearing oneself chant, one also benefits by hearing the chanting of others." (*Chant and*

Be Happy). Just as our experience is heightened when we share a music concert, a sports game or a night of dance with friends, the spiritual benefit of chanting is felt more intensely when done in a group. This shared meditation often builds in energy, creating feelings of euphoria and joy, as well as greater levels of self-expression and unity with others. This joyous connection with others helps us to understand our deepest soul relationship with God. Krishna Das, a well-known kirtan leader, describes this meditation process: "Chanting is meditation, a spiritual practice. It's not about whether you can carry a tune or keep a beat. You also need to realize that nobody is listening to you. It's about overcoming the shyness at first – opening up a little bit and relaxing. As the mind gets quieter, you begin to enter into the blissful states of consciousness that also pass. But your true self never comes or goes. It is uncontrived, uncreated. It is who you are, and you learn how to reside in that. Chanting is part of paving the way to grace." (Krishna Das in *American Yoga.*) Kirtan simultaneously engages the senses, mind, body and heart.

Kirtan as *Yoga*

Yoga means the process of connecting with the Divine. Kirtan is a verbal and audible call to the Supreme. Kirtan is a yoga practice that reveals the heart. God lives within each of us, inside our hearts. Singer Jai Uttal says, "When we chant we are tearing open our chests, opening our hearts to reveal our true identity and finding God there." (*Jivamukti Yoga*.) Kirtan is a direct way to call out in prayer to the Lord. "The yearning in the voice that touches your heartstrings helps you recognize that the longing such singers express is the same longing we all feel in our hearts. It is the universal plea of the soul. It is the soul's yearning to go home." (Ibid.) This is the ultimate spiritual form of self-expression.

Kirtan is a spiritual practice, or sadhana, that gradually leads us through a cleansing process, working on our past activity, or karma, to clear the conditioning of many lifetimes. Ultimately, it lifts us to a level of consciousness devoid of offenses, giving us a taste of our true and eternal self in relationship with God and our fellow living entities.



"Chanting the Names of God is one of the devotional practices that can dissolve the feeling of separateness from the Beloved. Chanting utilizes the body, mind and emotions. But here is the mystery: what we experience as the longing for God, is really God pulling us from within, pulling us into Him/Herself." (Krishna Das, *One Track Heart*)

This practice of calling out with all our emotions helps us to purify our thoughts, activities and goals in order to overcome our conditioned state of anxiety and confusion and restore us to our original consciousness of eternal bliss and knowledge. During the cleansing stages, the benefits of kirtan practice become apparent as we begin to naturally desire a lifestyle more beneficial for the practice of yoga. This includes adopting a vegetarian diet, living without intoxication, and developing

a service mood toward both God and our fellow living entities. Sri Chaitanya, renowned for the reawakening of kirtan in the modern age, describes the cleansing process of chanting in his Shiksastaka prayers: "Kirtan cleanses the heart of all the dust accumulated for years and extinguishes the fire of conditional life, of repeated birth and death... It increases the ocean of transcendental bliss, and it enables us to fully taste the nectar for which we are always anxious."

The ultimate goal of kirtan is to call out to God with a pure heart. It is through chanting that our hearts become cleansed. Chanting just one name of God with purity and unconditional love provides eternal benefits to the heart and soul.

Chapter 2

Kit Components

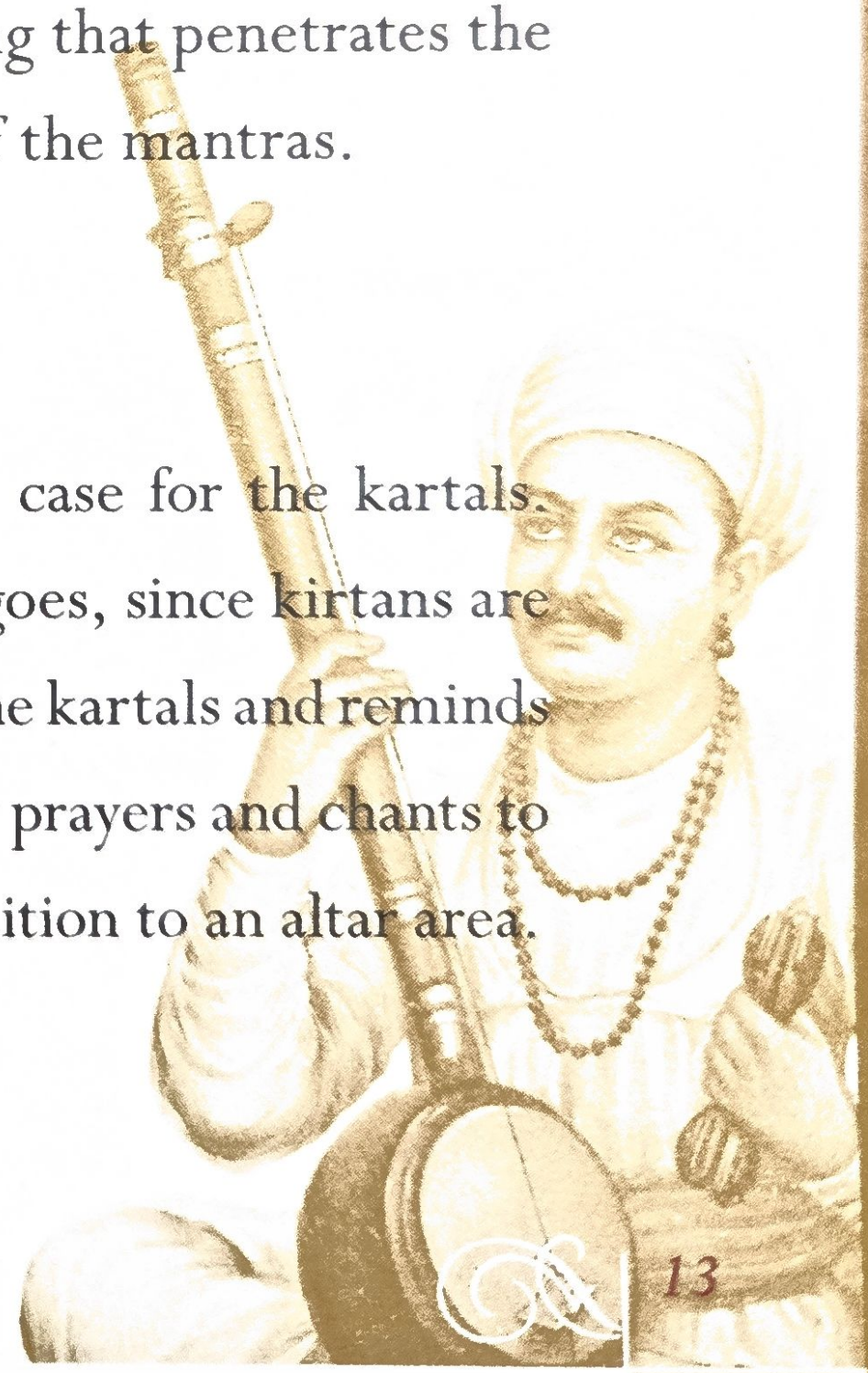
Kartals

The instruments most commonly used in kirtan are cymbals (known as kartals), mridanga drum and harmonium. However, any instrument can be added to participate in the joy of kirtan. Even those without an instrument can clap to fully participate.

Kartals are the traditional cymbal instrument used to accompany kirtans and are presented in this kit. They have a sweet ring that penetrates the consciousness and allows us to enter the rhythm of the mantras.

Kartal *Pouch*

A beautiful pouch has been included as a carrying case for the kartals. This allows kartals to be taken along wherever one goes, since kirtans are possible almost anywhere. The pouch also protects the kartals and reminds us to treat them as sacred objects used to accompany prayers and chants to the Supreme. The ornamental pouch is a perfect addition to an altar area.



Song *Cards*

The song cards included allow the listener to follow along and participate with the kirtans on the CD. They can also be used to create kirtans of your own.

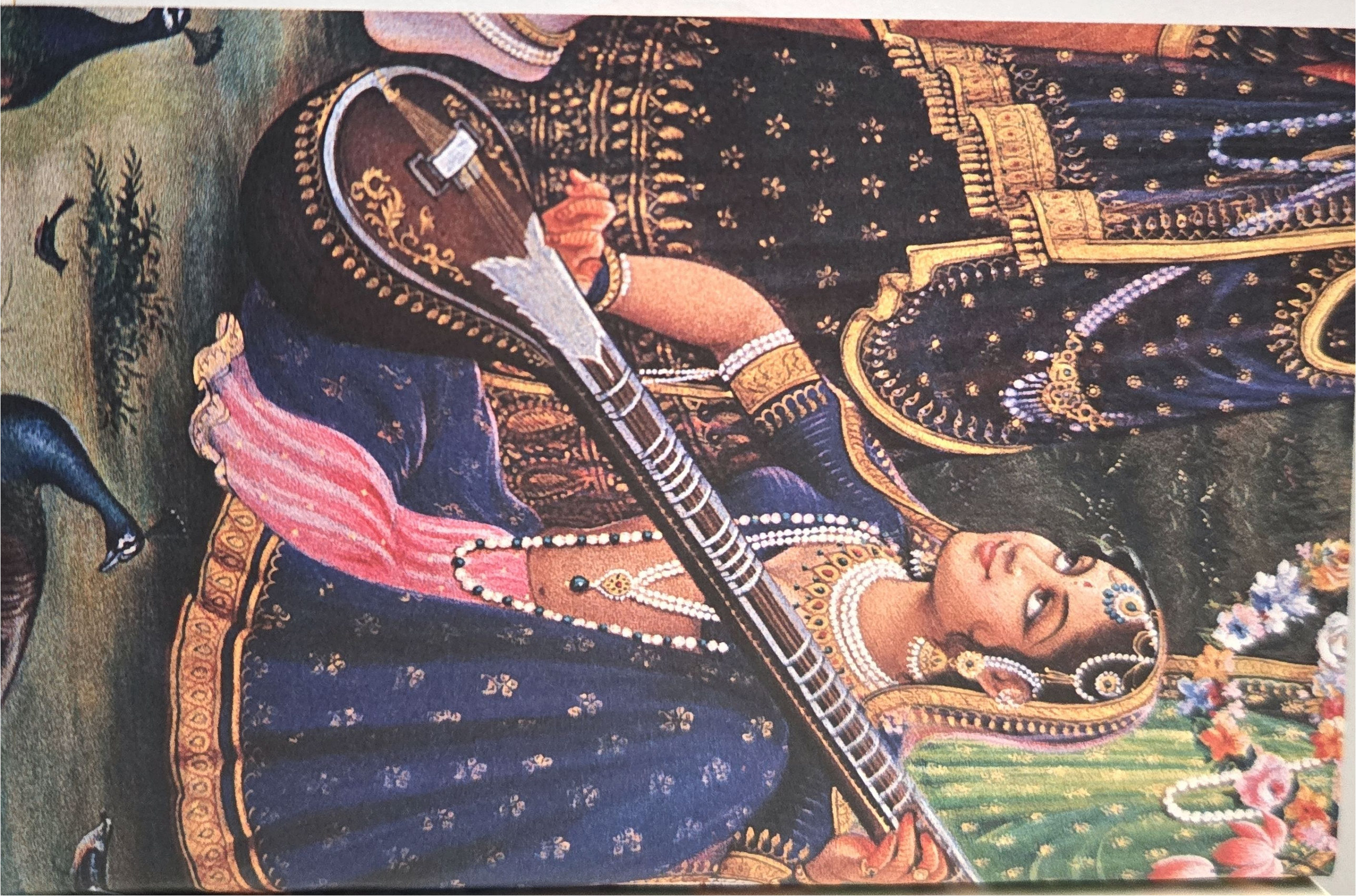
Compact *Discs*

The compact discs included in this kit include a sampling of both contemporary and traditional styles of kirtan. The sampling displays the variety of moods that can be achieved in kirtan. The contemporary recordings were recorded in sound studios and professionally produced, bringing together the authenticity of the mantra and the smooth sounds of modern musical and instrumental expression. The traditional recordings were recorded in temples in India and reveal the live meditation in practice. The sound quality reveals the mysterious and rustic experience of kirtan meditation in its place of origin.

B.G. Sharma

Chapter 3

How to Participate in Kirtan



Kirtan in Different *Forms and Settings*

Kirtan can be integrated into one's lifestyle in various ways. It can be incorporated as a sadhana, or spiritual practice, or as an invocation or closing for meetings, performances, or any type of gathering. In the Indian traditions, kirtan accompanies most ceremonies, such as weddings, funerals, births, and hundreds of other rites of passage. Kirtan can comprise many different moods, such as joy and sadness, and can also serve as a plea for protection, a healing method, or a cry for soothing the pain of one's heart. There are various kirtans that may be sung from the beginning of each day until sunset. They can build in tempo, or remain as a steady meditation. However, in all cases the purpose is the same: to bring the Divine presence into the group in a real and experiential way. One can participate in kirtan and gain benefit at all levels of realization.

Creating Your Own *Kirtan Practice*

The best way to become more familiar with kirtan is to participate in it with others. You may have access to kirtans at yoga centers or temples

in your area, or you may want to gather with others to learn and explore this practice together.

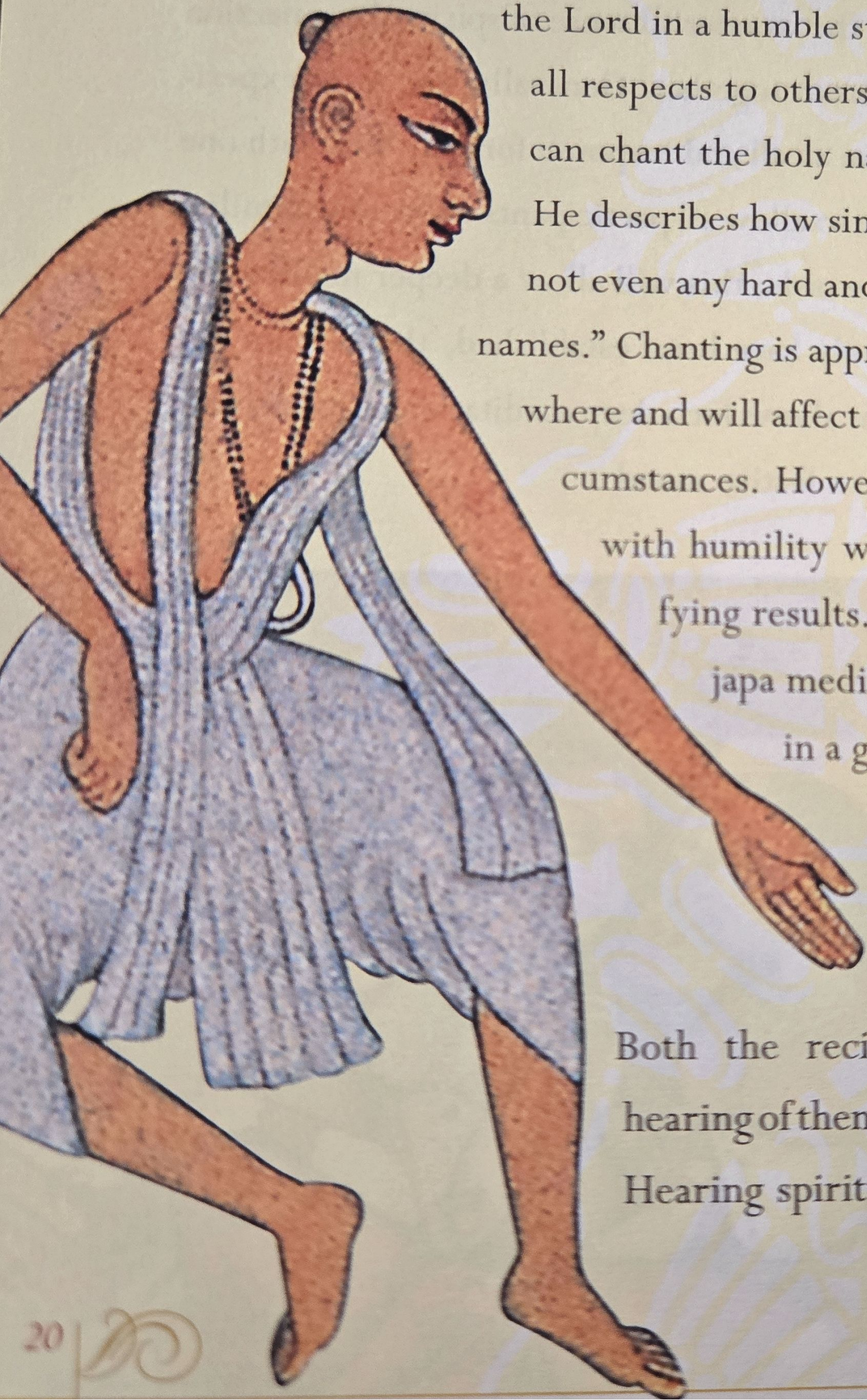
If you are a true beginner to kirtan and want to practice alone, the first step may be to sit in a place that you consider appropriate for meditation, like in front of your altar or out in nature. Use the song cards included in the kit to sing along with the CD kirtans or recreate these mantra songs on your own. If you are doing this on your own, choose a kirtan that is familiar or simple enough to allow you to stop using the song card after a few repetitions. This will allow you to absorb yourself more deeply in the sacred sounds of the kirtan. Clap along to create the rhythm. Sway or dance with the sound and rhythm as you feel inspired.

If you want to gather people to practice kirtan together, encourage clapping and the use of instruments (see the description of instruments commonly used in kirtan). If everyone present is new to this practice, remind them that it is not necessary to be a musician to pour your heart into kirtan. Create a non-judgmental environment that encourages everyone's partici-

pation. This will contribute to the wonderful sense of spiritual connection that can result in singing in kirtan together. Generally, the most experienced person leads the kirtan in a call and response format. Stay with one mantra or phrase for some time to allow all participants to become familiar with both the melody and the words; this will allow a deeper meditation. Once the mantra and its melody have been established, the rhythm can either stay at a single tempo that allows for a deep meditation or it can build to a faster tempo that generates a festive mood.

How to *Chant*

While the chanting of mantras is a profound, ancient science, it is simultaneously a simple and accessible method of yoga. Sri Chaitanya states in his Shiksastaka, "One should chant the holy name of



the Lord in a humble state of mind... ready to offer all respects to others. In such a state of mind one can chant the holy name of the Lord constantly." He describes how simple it is to chant: "There are not even any hard and fast rules for chanting these names." Chanting is appropriate anywhere and everywhere and will affect one's consciousness in all circumstances. However, chanting attentively and with humility will bestow the greatest purifying results. This applies both to solitary japa meditation and to singing mantras in a group.

Hearing and *Chanting*

Both the recitation of mantras and the hearing of them are important and beneficial. Hearing spiritual sound vibrations is called

sravanam and reciting mantras is called kirtanam. These are a few of the glorified methods for following the process of bhakti yoga, the yoga of devotion to the Supreme Lord.

Dance

One can either sit or stand during kirtans, but they often inspire spontaneous dance. Chanting of the Holy Name accompanied by clapping and the playing of instruments touches the rhythm of our beating hearts, so that we are often moved to dance and experience the joy of kirtan with body, mind and spirit. That which is evoked in the heart manifests in the body. Dancing and chanting are a perfect combination for diving deep into the bliss of kirtan and can bring us to a state of complete ecstasy.

Using Your *Kartals*

PREPARING TO PLAY KARTALS:

- Hold one kartal by the cloth strap in your left hand about 3 to 4 inches from where it connects to the cymbal.
- Wrap the cloth strap around your left index finger 2 or 3 times and hold the strap down with your thumb so you have a firm grasp on the kartal.
- Repeat the same with the right hand to hold the second cymbal, but allow a slight amount of slack between your wrapped finger and the kartal. This will allow the sound to resonate.
- Generally (if you are right-handed), the left hand is kept stationary while your right hand is active by lifting and striking the left kartal to produce a beat.

A Common kartal beat:

- The most common and simple beat for kartals can be heard on the track of the *Hare Krishna Maha Mantra* by Agni Deva (Disc One, Track 6). This is a four (1-2-3-4) beat that is enhanced by kartals as 1-2-3 . . . Strike the kartals on 1, 2, and 3. Then pause slightly on the fourth beat, keeping the right kartal lifted for the pause to allow the sound to resonate like a tuning fork.

- It may take listening and a little practice to get the beat and get used to holding, striking and resonating the kartals, but playing along to the CD will help. It may help to simply start with clapping to the beat described: 1-2-3 . . . 1-2-3 . . . 1-2-3.

Other Kirtan *Instruments*

Mridanga Drum

The word 'mridanga' is derived from mrid (clay) and anga (body), meaning that it is an instrument, a drum in this case, whose body or shell is made of clay. According to other sources, it derives from mridan and ga, meaning "beaten while moving," as its design permits the drum to be hung around the neck and played while walking or dancing.

This instrument has a unique history connected to the cultural and spiritual revolution reignited by Sri Chaitanya in sixteenth-century Bengal. It is said that Sri Chaitanya ordered his associates to construct clay drums instead of heavy and costly wooden drums.

A number of mridanga playing styles developed, known as Manoharshayi, Mandarini and Garanhati. These schools trace their lineages back to Srinivas Acharya, Shyamananda Pandit and Narottam Das Thakur, respectively. Though these ancient traditions have undergone change and are rarely practiced in their original form, the mridanga continues to be popular in the sacred music of India and beyond.

According to the Manoharshayi school, Lord Krishna's flute pleaded with him not to be left behind when he incarnated as Sri Chaitanya. Krishna thus allowed the flute to accompany him in his advent as Sri Chaitanya in the mridanga form.

It is also said that Sri Chaitanya prayed to the famous deity Lord Jagannath for the mantras with which to play the mridanga. The revelation of these mantras was then given to Gadadhar Pandit, who became the first player of this divine instrument.

Harmonium

The harmonium is a western instrument that originated in Germany and England and became popular among nineteenth-century immigrant pioneers in the American West. Around the same time, the British brought the harmonium to India, where it was quickly absorbed into Indian musical culture. Though not a traditional Indian instrument, it was admired for its portability and drone quality, which made it uniquely appropriate to the Indian aesthetic.

Chapter 4

More on Kirtan

The Power of *Sound Vibration*

From ancient times to the modern day, song and dance unifies people in celebration and self-expression. From rebellious passion to mundane sentimentality, music and sound have always been an integral part of human spiritual expression and experience.

Both consciously and unconsciously, sound vibrations have a deep effect on our state of being, as they impact the rhythm of our body, heart and consciousness. We all know how simply hearing our favorite music creates joy, excitement or relaxation in the body and mind. The use of suspenseful music in motion pictures greatly enhances feelings of fear and anticipation. "Music helps plants to grow, drives our neighbors to distraction, lulls children to sleep, and marches men to war." (*The Mozart Effect.*) This principle of sound vibration also relates to deep levels of spiritual consciousness. Just as music can change our mood in ways that we don't fully comprehend, sound can have a transformative effect on our consciousness and subconscious, as well as on the depths of one's heart. Conscious use of spiritual sound vibration has tremendous power

to elevate our spiritual awareness.

Everything in existence and the very nature of our being is comprised of vibration. "Rhythmic patterns appear throughout the universe, from the very small to the very large. Atoms are patterns of probability waves, molecules are vibrating structures, and living organisms manifest multiple, interdependent patterns of fluctuation. Plants, animals and human beings undergo cycles of activity and rest, and all their physiological functions oscillate in rhythms of various periodicities. The components of ecosystems are interlinked through cyclical exchanges of matter and energy; civilizations rise and fall in evolutionary cycles, and the planet as a whole has its rhythms and recurrences as it spins around its axis and moves around the sun." (*The World is Sound*). Atomic vibration reflects the light we see and manifests the matter we touch. These innumerable rhythmic frequencies create our universe. When we understand the significance of sound vibration in our existence, we can understand how it may be used for healing and spiritual transformation. Spiritual sound vibration can be used universally to elevate all areas of our lives.

Mantras

Mantras are universal sound vibrations. When chanted properly, they bring about specific effects on the mind and consciousness. Sanskrit mantras are used for spiritual purposes in rituals and meditations. They play a significant role in the yogic process by controlling the mind, purifying the heart and promoting devotion to God. Mantra meditation involves deep concentration on sacred sound vibration. The more often mantras are chanted, the more powerful the result.

The ancient Vedic teachings of India describe that specific transcendental mantras affect the vibrations of our own body, mind, heart and consciousness, and thus have the power to profoundly impact our lives. Mantras have the power to free the mind and open the heart. Patrick Bernard explains that "the Sanskrit word 'mantra' means 'mental liberation.' This sound, or combination of sounds, delivers the mind from its worldly conditioning and limitations... Mantras are found in all cultures, traditions and religious systems. The genuine goal of practicing mantras, however, is to connect

oneself to the Divine." (*Music As Yoga*). Mantras are not just random sound, but ancient incantations with specific meaning and intent. They are not just audible to the ear vibrating on the physical plane; they resonate and purify on the physical, subtle and soul levels. The great Indian saint Saraswati Thakur said, "If we serve the [mantra of the] Holy Name in body, mind and soul, then the direction of that service spontaneously manifests like the sun in the clear sky of the chanter's heart." Mantra meditation has powerful effects on the mind and heart by engaging the senses in transcendental sound vibration.

Probably the most well-known and commonly used mantra is the syllable AUM (Om). The Vedic understanding is that all creation originated from this sound. It was this first sound that sparked consciousness in the demigod Brahma before he could begin the first act of material creation. The Vedas describe this transcendental sound vibration as the manifestation of the enchanting sound of Krishna's flute. "Chanting Om holds the power to cleanse the mind. This purification process eliminates all karmic dust accumulated from time immemorial." (Ibid.) Thus, we can understand that this vibration is tremendously important,

since all of creation, manifest and unmanifest, resides within it.

The mantra recommended for this particular age is the Hare Krishna Maha Mantra. Maha means "the greatest." This mantra is thus said to be the most complete and powerful, encompassing all other mantras. It can bring one to a state of pure devotion to God, the ultimate goal of yoga. This mantra, Hare Krishna Hare Krishna Krishna Krishna Hare Hare/ Hare Rama Hare Rama Rama Rama Hare Hare, has been

uttered throughout Vedic history. However, Sri Chaitanya popularized this mantra in congregational chanting, also known as sankirtan. In the Chaitanya-charitamrita, the text describing Sri Chaitanya's life, it is said that "after searching through all the Vedic literature, one cannot find a method of religion more sublime for this age than the chanting of Hare Krishna." This pure sound vibration is said to be directly imported from the spiritual realm. A.C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada explains the meaning of this mantra: "These three words, namely Hare, Krishna and Rama, are the transcendental seeds of the Maha Mantra. The chanting is a spiritual call for the Lord and His [feminine] energy to give protection to the conditioned soul. This chanting is exactly like the genuine cry of a child for its mother's presence. Mother Hara helps the devotee achieve the Lord Father's grace, and the Lord reveals himself to the devotee who chants the mantra sincerely." (*The Science of Self-Realization.*) This mantra is suitable for both kirtan and japa (described below).

There are innumerable mantras for many different purposes; however, it is important to understand that the most powerful transcendental

sound vibrations fulfill all intentions and desires, both spiritual and material. Mantras have benefits whether you know their literal meaning or not; however, understanding both the meaning and spiritual intention contained within the words often deepens the meditation for the practitioner. Mantras can be used both in solitary meditation and in congregational chanting.

Chanting the *Names of God*

Transcendental sound vibration is used throughout the world in all cultures. The specific uttering of the names of God, also known as Holy Names, has been given special significance. The quotes below will illuminate this point. From these we can see how repetition of God's names has been emphasized in all prominent spiritual traditions. Chanting, singing and meditating upon the names of God are universal methods to connect with the Divine.

"Let us offer sacrifice of praise to God continually, that is, the fruit of our lips giving thanks to His name." (Hebrews XXII. 15)

Prophet Muhammed was asked, "O Prophet of God, truly the laws of Islam are numerous. Tell me of one thing through which I can obtain reward." The Prophet replied: "Let thy tongue be always moist in the remembrance of Allah."

"One must learn to call upon the name of God, even more than breathing – at all times, in all places, in every kind of occupation."

— Orthodox Christian text, Philokalia

"O my Lord, Your holy name alone can render all benedictions to living beings, and thus You have hundreds and millions of names like Krishna and Govinda. In these transcendental names You have invested all Your transcendental energies."

— Shiksastaka

"Repeat the name of Amida Buddha with all your heart. Whether walking or standing, sitting or lying down, never cease the practice of it even for a moment. This is the very work which unfailingly issues in salvation, for it is in accordance with the Original Vow of that Buddha."

— Zendo, the great Chinese advocate of the Pure Land Buddhist doctrine

"There is no difference between the Holy Name of the Lord and the Lord Himself. As such, the holy name is as perfect as the Lord Himself."

— Padma Purana

"There is one supreme God who is, as it were, the God and almighty father of all. It is Him who we worship under many names."

— Maximus, philosopher

"The Holy Name is more compassionate than the Lord of the Name himself. If one takes shelter of the Name, then it unravels all philosophical complexities."

— Saraswati Thakur

"The name of the Lord is a strong tower: the righteous runneth into it and are safe."

— Old Testament

"All nations whom Thou hast made shall come and worship before Thee, O Lord: and shall glorify Thy name.... O give thanks unto the Lord: call upon His name: make known His deeds among the people. Sing unto Him, sing psalms unto Him: talk ye of all His wondrous works. Glory ye in His holy name.... Praise Him with the timbrel and dance. Praise Him with stringed instruments and organs. Praise Him upon the loud cymbals."

—Psalms 86:9, 105:1–4 and 150:4–5

"Our Father, who art in Heaven, hallowed be Thy name."

— Jesus Christ

"I have found a haven for my heart, in the Harbor of the Name."

— Krishna Das

"I go where My devotees sing My glories." — Lord Krishna in Srimad Bhagavatam

"Chant the holy name, chant the holy name, chant the holy name of the Lord. In this age of quarrel and hypocrisy, there is no other way, no other way, no other way to attain spiritual enlightenment."

—Brihan-Naradiya Purana

History of *Kirtan*

Kirtan has its roots in the antiquity of Vedic culture, yet it has changed in more recent times. Specific songs were performed for ceremonies, temple gatherings and special events throughout Vedic history. However, they were generally performed by brahmins or kirtaniyas who were designated by birth.

Sri Chaitanya, prophesized as the incarnation of Divine Love by the Vedic scriptures, appeared in this world in the district of Nadia in West

Bengal, India, during the sixteenth century. He became prominent as a Sanskrit scholar and successfully debated his intellectual contemporaries. After taking initiation through mantra by his chosen spiritual master, Sri Chaitanya began teaching his students the deeper meaning of love of God. Sri Chaitanya had deeply studied Vedic philosophy and concluded that in this age of quarrel and hypocrisy, chanting the names of God aloud is the most effective means for attaining transcendental bliss and true union with the Supreme. He challenged the concept of restricted access to Vedic knowledge, which was supposedly the sole property of the brahmin caste, by making kirtan, the congregational chanting of mantra, accessible to all. He encouraged the simple chanting of the holy names as a practice for everyone. His spiritual and social revolution spread through dancing and chanting of the names of God. He traveled throughout India sharing the message of bhakti yoga, loving service to God. Following his departure, his disciples continued to share his message of devotional service to the Divine through chanting. This knowledge and practice has been passed from teacher to disciple to the present day. His message has now spread around the world and people of

all continents of the world practice yoga through blissful congregational chanting of the Lord's names. Sri Chaitanya's teachings continue to be relevant, sweetly captivating, and a powerful means of union with the Supreme.

Kirtan is becoming increasingly popular in the West in these times of confusion, chaos and war. The practice of chanting has been recommended for this time since we rarely have the ability to still our mind. The Brihan Naradiya Purana states:

Harer nâma harer nâma harer nâmaiva kevalam
kalau nâsty eva nâsty eva nasty eva gatir anyatha

Chant the Holy Name, Chant the Holy Name,
Chant the Holy Name of the Lord

In this age of quarrel and hypocrisy, there is no other way, no other way, no other way to attain spiritual enlightenment.

Chapter 5

Songs

Râma Bolo

(Traditional Chant)

râma bolo râma bolo, bolo bolo râm
sitâ bolo sitâ bolo, bolo bolo râm
hanumân bolo hanumân bolo, bolo bolo râm

Sing the names of God!

"Oh my friends, sing the Name of God!
When life becomes too hard, just sing.

Have no fear, don't give up. Sing! When it gets too good, sing.
When it falls apart, sing. When it comes together, sing.
Cry and sing. Sing and cry. Living sing. Dying sing.
Listening sing. Singing sing."

—Krishna Das

Sri Râdhikâ-stava

(A Hymn to Sri Radha)

by Rupa Goswami

râdhe jaya jaya mâdhava-dayite
gokula-taruni-mandala-mahite
(refrain)

O Radha, all glories to you, beloved of Madhava! You are worshiped by all the young girls of Gokul!

dâmodara-rati-vardhana-veshe
hari-nishkuta-vrindâ-vipineshe
(1)

Radha! You dress yourself a way that increases Lord Damodar's love and attachment for you! You are the queen of his pleasure grove, Vrindavan.

vrishabhânu-dadhi-nava-shashi-lekhe
lalitâ-sakhi guna-ramita-vishâkhe
(2)

O new moon, risen from the ocean of King Vrishabhanu! O friend of Lalita! You enchant Vishakha with your wonderful qualities.

karunâm kuru mayi karunâ-bharite
sanaka-sanâtana-varnita-carite
(3)

O you who are filled with compassion!
O you whose divine characteristics are described by the great sages Sanaka and Sanatan! O Radhe!
Please be merciful to me!

OHE! VAISHNAVA THÂKURA!

(Oh Holy Saint!)

by Bhaktivinoda Thakur

ohe! vaishnava thâkura, doyâra sâgara,
e dâse korunâ kori
diyâ pada-châyâ, shodho he âmây,
tomâra carana dhori
(1)

O venerable Vaishnava, O ocean of mercy, be merciful unto your servant. Give me the shade of your lotus feet and purify me. I hold on to your lotus feet.

choy bega domi, choy dosha shodhi,
choy guna deho dâse

Disc One *Track 3*

choy sat-sanga, deho he âmâre,
boshechi sangera âshe
(2)

Teach me to control the six passions and rectify the six faults. Bestow upon me the six qualities and offer unto me the six kinds of holy companionship. I sit here in the hope of having your association.

ekâki âmâra, nâhi pâya bala,
hari-nâma-sankirtane
tumi kripâ kori, shraddhâ-bindu diyâ,
deho krishna-nâma-dhane
(3)

Alone I do not find the strength to carry on the sankirtan of Hari's holy name. Please bless me by giving me the

one drop of the faith I need to obtain the great
treasure of Krishna's holy name.

krishna se tomâra, krishna dite pâro,
tomâra shakati âche
âmi to kângâla, krishna krishna boli,
dhâi tava pâche pâche

(4)

Krishna is yours; you have the power to give him to me.
I am simply running behind you, calling out
his names, "Krishna! Krishna!"

Namah Shivâya

(Traditional Chant)

om namah shivâya
shivâya namah, shivâya namah om
shivâya namah, namah shivâya
shambhu shankara namah shivâya
girijâ shankara namah shivâya
arunâchala shiva namah shivâya

I offer homage to Shiva, again and again. I offer obeisance to Shiva, the auspicious one, who is also known as Shambhu, the one who is situated in complete peace, and Shankara, the one who bestows such peace on his devotees. I bow down to Shiva, the husband of the goddess Parvati. I offer obeisance to Shiva, who resides in the Dawn Mountains.

Shiva is the supreme yogi and is in constant meditation on Lord Vishnu. He is full of compassion and gives shelter to all. One should approach Lord Shiva in order to purify one's material pursuits.

The Glories of Sri Râdhâ

jai râdhe! jai krishna! jai vrindâvan!
rasika mukuta mani jai gopi gan

All glories to Radha, all glories to Krishna,
and their village of Vrindavan!
All glories to the gopis,
the crown jewels of all the rasikas!

râdhe râdhe rate shyâm râdhâ rate shyâm shyâm
râdhe shyâma yugala nâma mero hai jivan

Shyama chants "Radhe! Radhe!" and Radha chants "Shyama!
Shyama!" The names "Radhe Shyama" are my very existence.

Disc One *Track 5*

mero eka prâna dhana eka hi hai jivan
nanda-nandan madana-mohan râdhikâ raman...

The sole treasure of my life is Krishna,
the son of Nanda, the enchanter of Cupid,
and the lover of Radha.

shyâma hi so mero pyâra shyâma hi mero bharatar
shyâma hi samâyo âtho yama tana mana....

Shyama is my love; Shyama is my master. He fills my
body and mind throughout the day and night.
main to haun vahi sahachari râdhe râni ki
nitya dhama vrindâvan mahârâni ki...

I want to become the friend and companion
of Srimati Radharani, the queen of the
eternal abode of Vrindavan.

nitya dhâma nitya sevâ nitya pâuṇ âtho yama
râkho ruci soi joi thâkurâni ki…

I want to achieve her eternal service in her eternal abode.
I therefore wish to live my life the way the goddess wishes.

Disc One *Track 5*

Maha Mantra

(Traditional Chant)

Hare Krishna Hare Krishna
Krishna Krishna Hare Hare
Hare Rama Hare Rama
Rama Rama Hare Hare

Maha means "the greatest." This mantra is thus said to be the most complete and powerful mantra. It encompasses all other mantras and can bring one to a state of pure devotion to God, the ultimate goal of yoga.

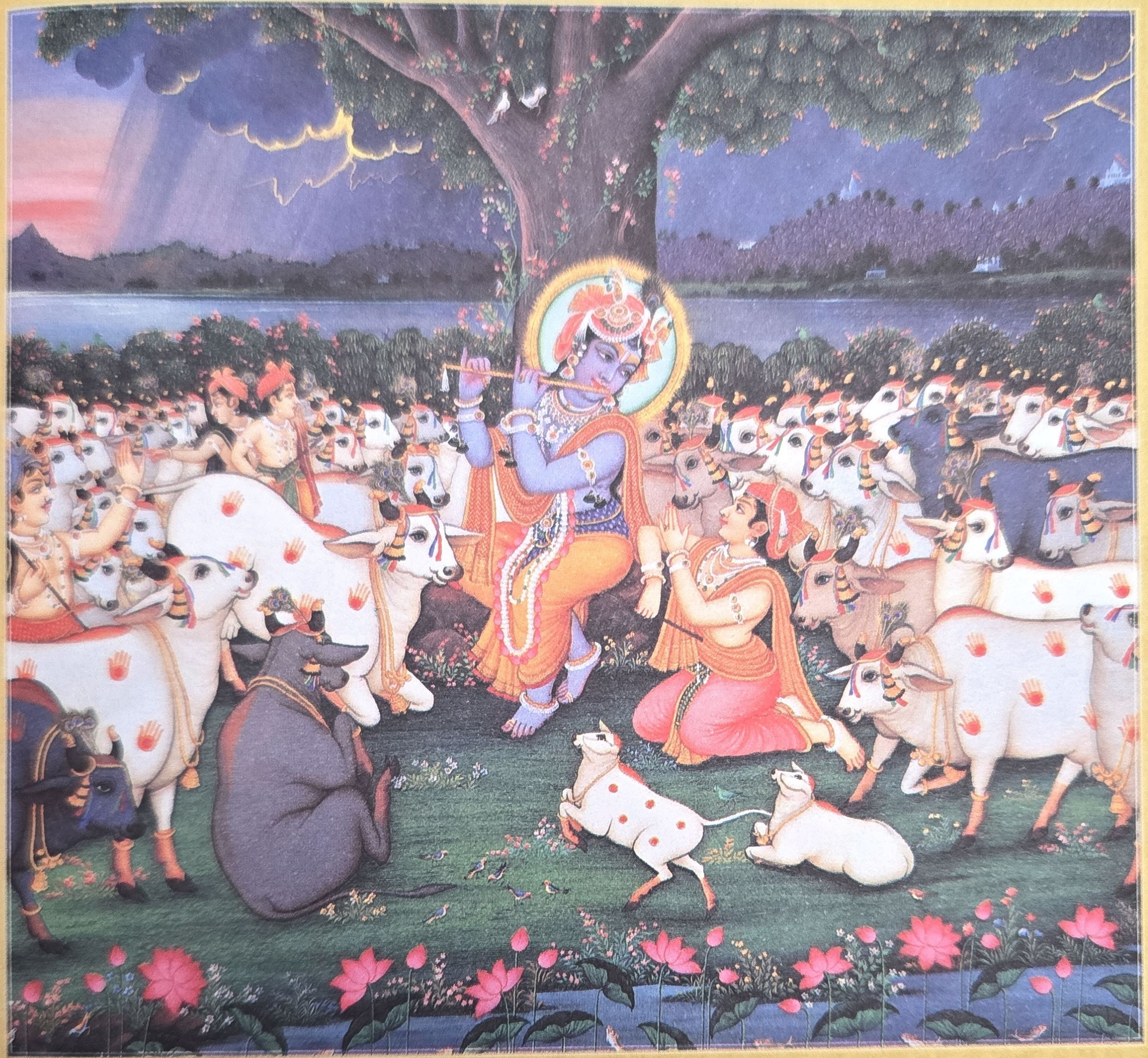
Prayers of Draupadi

(Traditional Chant)

sri krishna govinda hare murâre
he nâtha nârâyana vâsudeva
he nâtha nârâyana vâsudeva
he nâtha nârâyana vâsudeva

Sri Krishna, O all attractive one!
Govinda, O pleasure of my senses!
O Hari, who takes away all suffering!
Murari, O remover of all obstacles!
Nath, O Master!
O Narayan, the resting place of creation!
O Vasudeva, creator of the universe!

Disc One *Track 7*



Jaya Râdhâ Ramana Hari Bol

(Traditional Chant)

Jaya Râdhâ Ramana Hari Bol
Jaya Râdhâ Ramana Hari Bol
Hari Bol Hari Bol

Let us all glorify the names of the Lord,
the lover of Radharani.

Disc Two *Track 2*

Jaya Râdhâ Mâdhava

by Bhaktivinoda Thakur

(jaya) râdhâ-mâdhava (jaya) kunja-vihâri
gopi-jana-vallabha (jaya) giri-vara-dhâri
yashodâ-nandana, vraja-jana-ranjana,
jamunâ-tira-vanachâri

All glories to Sri Radha and Madhava!
All glories to Kunja Bihari, the gopis' dearmost beloved.
He lifted Govardhan Hill and is the darling son of
Yashoda-maiya. He wanders in the forests along the banks
of the Yamuna, where he enjoys with the many different
gopis (vanachari) in their own groves.

Jaya Jaya Dèva Hare

(Sri Mangala-Gitam)

By Jayadeva Gosvami

râdhe krishna govinda gopâla
nanda-dulâla yashodâ-dulâla
jaya jaya deva! Hare
(refrain)

shrita-kamalâ-kucha-mandala! dhrita-kundala e !
kalita-lalita-vanamâlâ! jaya jaya deva haŕe!
(1)

O Krishna! You take shelter of the breast of Srimati Radhika, the source of all goddesses of fortune! You wear fish-shaped earrings and a charming garland of forest flowers! Deva! Hare! All glories to you!

Disc Two *Track 5*

dina-mani-mandala-mandana! bhava-khandana e !
muni-jana-mânasa-hamsa! jaya jaya deva hare!

(2)

O Krishna, you who are the supreme ornament of the entire solar system! You sever the bondage of the material world! O swan who delightfully wanders on the pond of thoughtful sages' minds! Deva! Hare! All glories to you!

kaliya-vishadhara-ganjana! jana-ranjana e !
yadu-kula-nalina-dinesha! jaya jaya deva hare!

(3)

O vanquisher of the poisonous Kaliya's arrogance and enchanter of the residents of Braja! You are the sun that causes the lotus flower of the Yadu dynasty to bloom! Deva! Hare! All glories to you!

madhu-mura-naraka-vinâshana! garudâsana e!
sura-kula-keli-nidana! jaya jaya deva hare!

(4)

O destroyer of the Madhu, Mura and Naraka demons! You ride on the back of the eagle Garuda! You are the origin of the gods' happiness! Deva! Hare! All glories to you!

amala-kamala-dala-locana! bhava-mocana e!
tri-bhuvana-bhavana-nidhana! jaya jaya deva hare!

(5)

O Krishna! Your large eyes are like spotless lotus petals!
You liberate souls from the material condition!
O Lord, foundation of the three worlds! Deva! Hare!
All glories to you!

Disc Two *Track 5*

janaka-suta-krita-bhushana! jita-dushana e !
samara-shamita-dashakantha! jaya jaya deva hare!

(6)

O Krishna! When you appeared as Rama, you married Sita, the daughter of Janaka, and made her your ornament! You conquered the demon Dushana and defeated the ten-headed Ravana in battle! Deva! Hare! All glories to you!

abhinava-jaladhara-sundara! dhrita-mandara e !
sri-mukha-chandra-chakora! jaya jaya deva hare!

(7)

O Shyamasundara, your beauty is like that of a fresh raincloud! You held up Giriraja (Mandara)! Like the chakora bird, you are enamored of the moon of Srimati Radhika's face! Deva! Hare! All glories to you!

tava charane pranatâ vayam iti bhâvaya e !
kuru kushalam pranateshu, jaya jaya deva hare!
(8)

O Lord! Consider us surrendered to your lotus feet. Please be kind to those who have surrendered to you. Deva! Hare!
All glories to you!

sri-jayadeva-kaver idam kurute mudam
mangalam ujjvala-gitam, jaya jaya deva hare!
(9)

O Deva! May this brilliantly shining, auspicious song composed by the poet Jayadeva always bring pleasure to you and the devotees who sing and hear it. Deva! Hare!
All glories to you!

Disc Two *Track 5*

Rama Krishna Vasudeva

(Traditional Chant)

Râma Krishna Vâsudeva
Jagannâtha Hari Hari
Râma Krishna Vâsudeva
Jagannatha Hari Hari

Râma Krishna Vâsudeva
Sri Gaurânga Hari Hari
Râma Krishna Vâsudeva
Sri Gaurânga Hari Hari

Râma Krishna Vâsudeva
Gopinâtha Hari Hari
Râma Krishna Vâsudeva
Gopinâtha Hari Hari

Râma Krishna Vâsudeva
Nityânanda Hari Hari
Râma Krishna Vâsudeva
Nityânanda Hari Hari

Disc Two *Track 7*

Govinda Mantra
(Traditional Chant)

govinda jaya jaya, gopâla jaya jaya
râdhâ-ramana hari, govinda jaya jaya

Govinda and Gopal are childhood names of Krishna.
Govinda is the source of pleasure to the senses.
The sense are truly satisfied when they are absorbed in
Govinda, who steals the heart of Cupid himself.
This mantra will satisfy the senses,
giving one contentment and joy.

Traditional

Pancha Tattva Mantra

(Traditional Chant)

sri krishna chaitanya
prabhu nityânanda
sri advaita gadâdhara
srivâsâdi-gaura-bhakta-vrinda

Krishna Chaitanya is the most magnanimous incarnation of God. His mercy is easily achieved by chanting this mantra, enabling us to come to the platform of loving service to the Supreme.

Nrisingha Mantras

(From the Puranas)

This is a prayer for protection from external and internal dangers. Lord Nrisingha is the half-man, half-lion form of Vishnu. This mantra fortifies faith and tolerance.

Nrisingha Pranam

namas te narasinghâya
prahlâdahlâda-dâyine
hiranyakashipor vakshah-
shila-tankâ-nakhâlaye

Traditional

ito nrisimhah parato nrisingho
yato yato yâmi tato nrisinghaù
bahir nrisingho hrdaye nrisingho
nrisingham âdim sharanam prapadye

I offer my obeisances to Lord Nrisingha Deva, who is always
giving bliss to his devotees like Prahlada Maharaj and
chiseling at the hearts of demons like Hiranyakashipu.
The devotee always sees Lord Nrisingha everywhere. Lord
Nrisingha is within and without. Therefore,
let us all take shelter of Lord Nrisingha.

Aum: An alternative spelling of the syllable 'om' said in Indian scripture to be the original sound vibration from which all of creation emerged, and also the sound representation of the Supreme Person.

Bhakti yoga: The spiritual path of loving devotion to the Supreme Lord. The purity of such devotion is determined by the degree to which it is devoid of desire for fruitive results or for merging one's individuality into the Lord's impersonal aspect.

Brahmin: The priestly class of the Indian caste system. Being more highly educated than the other castes, especially in religious matters, they are responsible for providing society with spiritual guidance.

Hare: A word of address found in the famed

Maha Mantra. A way of calling out to the Supreme Person, it is also said to refer to his feminine energy.

Harmonium: A keyboard instrument on which notes are produced when air is driven through metal reeds by hand-operated bellows. Originating in Europe, it was introduced to India by the British and has since been incorporated as traditional accompaniment to Indian devotional music.

Japa: The Hindu practice of repeatedly chanting the Lord's holy names, usually in mantra form, on a string of prayer beads. This is a personal meditation usually performed in solitude.

Karma: The ancient Indian doctrine of cause and effect that governs all of one's activities, which includes the accumulation of merits and demerits procured through the course of many lifetimes.

Kartals: Hand cymbals that traditionally accompany Indian devotional music. The easiest to play of commonly used Indian instruments, they

are said to produce a sound that strikes fear into the hearts of all demonic beings, both worldly and otherworldly.

Kirtan: Congregational chanting of the Lord's holy names, generally accompanied by music. Though it originally referred solely to devotional music in the traditional Indian style, it now regularly encompasses Western instruments and more contemporary styles.

Kirtanam: Literally translated as "glorification", Kirtanam refers to the practice of reciting, singing or speaking spiritual truths and praises of the Supreme Lord.

Kirtaniya: One who leads kirtan, or the congregational chanting of mantras and devotional songs, by dint of both his/her musical expertise and spiritual maturity.

Krishna: One the names of God found in the famed Maha Mantra. Krishna is renowned as the god of love and is perhaps the most popular

of all the gods described in the ancient Vedic literature of India.

Maha: A Sanskrit word literally meaning "great", it also implies topmost, best, or most superior.

Mantra: A spiritual sound vibration that delivers the mind from its material conditioning and illusory perceptions when repeated over and over; a Vedic hymn, prayer or chant.

Mridanga: A clay drum commonly used in Indian devotional music. Being lightweight and worn around the neck, it can be played while either sitting or standing and is especially useful for public processions.

Rama: Another name of the Supreme found in the Maha Mantra. It most commonly refers to the celebrated King Rama, who is considered the emblem of piety and virtue and whose story is told in the ancient Indian epic Ramayana. It is also an alternative name of the god Krishna.

Sadhana: An ancient Indian spiritual discipline that leads to an elevated state of spiritual awareness and ultimately to direct realization of the Supreme Being.

Sankirtan: See Kirtan above. The only distinction between the two is that sankirtan has a connotation of congregational chanting performed in public.

Sravanam: A Sanskrit word literally meaning "the act of listening," in general usage it refers to the purifying practice of hearing spiritual truth in the form of mantras, songs or discourses.

Yoga: Literally meaning "union", "meeting" or "connecting", this can refer to any number of spiritual disciplines originating in ancient India that elevate one's consciousness and ultimately link one to the Supreme Being.

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Liner Notes

Râma Bolo (10:22) and *Namah Shivaya* (7:16)
by Krishna Das

Krishna Das – vocals, harmonium, ektar
John McDowell – keyboards, djembe, gorong, tana, shakers, percussion
Bhima Karma Olrech – khol, cymbals
Jim Donovan – frame drum, bass drum, shakers
Hans Christian – cello, bass
Girish Gambhira – tabla
Steve Gorn – bansuri flute
Nina Rao – cymbals
Dagger-ji – shakers
The Ever Changing Kosmic Kirtan Posse
Produced by Krishna Das
(www.krishnadas.com)
Executive Producers: Krishna Das, John Friend, Mitchell Markus
From the CD *Live On Earth*
℗ 2002 Karuna LLC
To order : www.karunamusic.com, info@karunamusic.com

A Hymn to Sri Radha (6:11)
by Agni Deva

Agni Deva – lead vocals, kartals
Markandeya – tablas, mridanga
Vinode Vani – harmonium
Bhima Karma – mridanga
Hans Christian – sarangi, cello, bass, keyboards
Choir – response vocals
Produced by Hans Christian/Mandala Publishing
Forthcoming publication by Mandala

Vaishnava Thakura (7:02)
by As Kindred Spirits (Gaura Vani and Sandeep Mody)

Anapayini Jakupko – vocals
Gaura Vani – vocals, harmonium, bass guitar
Sandeep Mody – violin, backing vocals
Nandu Joshi – mrdanga drum
Sunanda Das – electric guitar
Radha Madhava Fitch – backing vocals
Kripa Oliver – trumpet

Produced by: Avatar Studios,
www.avatarstudios.org
From the CD *As Kindred Spirits: Nectar of Devotion*
℗ 2003 Avatar Studios. To order: www.krishna.com, 888.5-AVATAR

The Glories of Sri Radha (4:11)
by Karnamrita
Karnamrita – vocals
Anika & Ron Marinelli, Chaitanya, Nitai, Sakhya Rasa – backup vocals
Shiva – mrdangam, tabla & kartals
Leonice Shinneman,
Ron Marinelli – percussion
Produced by Karnamrita & Ron Marinelli
From the CD DASI: *Prayers for Women*
℗ 2005 Karnamrita
To order: www.karnamrita.com

Maha Mantra (11:35)
by Agni Deva
Agni Deva – lead vocals, kartals
Markandeya – tablas
Vinode Vani – harmonium
Hans Christian – sarangi, cello, bass, keyboards
Choir – response vocals
Produced by Hans Christian and Mandala Publishing Executive Producer: Raoul Goff
From the CD *Kirtan: Chanting the Names*
℗ 2002 Mandala Publishing
To order : www.mandala.org, 800.688.2218

Prayers of Draupadi (7:55)
by Karnamrita
Karnamrita – vocals
Anika & Ron Marinelli, Shakuntala, Mahalaksmi, Vishnurati – backup vocals
Shiva – mrdangam, kartals & shaker
Vocal Harmonies arranged by Ron Marinelli
Produced by Karnamrita & Ron Marinelli
From the CD *DASI: Prayers for Women*
℗ 2005 Karnamrita
To order: www.karnamrita.com

Morning Maha Mantra at Seva-kunja (9:02)
by Ananta Dasa
Shanti Ranjana Dasa – vocals, harmonium
Anadi Mohana Dasa – bansuri
Navadvipa Dasa – vocals, kartals
Shankara Dasa – khols
Executive Producer: Nick Dmitriev
From the CD *Ananda Bazâr*
℗ Long Arms Records 1998
To order:
www.avantart.com/longarms.html

This track was recorded in Vrindavan, India, the highest place of pilgrimage of the Hindus and the center of their religion and culture, which was described by the ancient scriptures as the land of the gods.

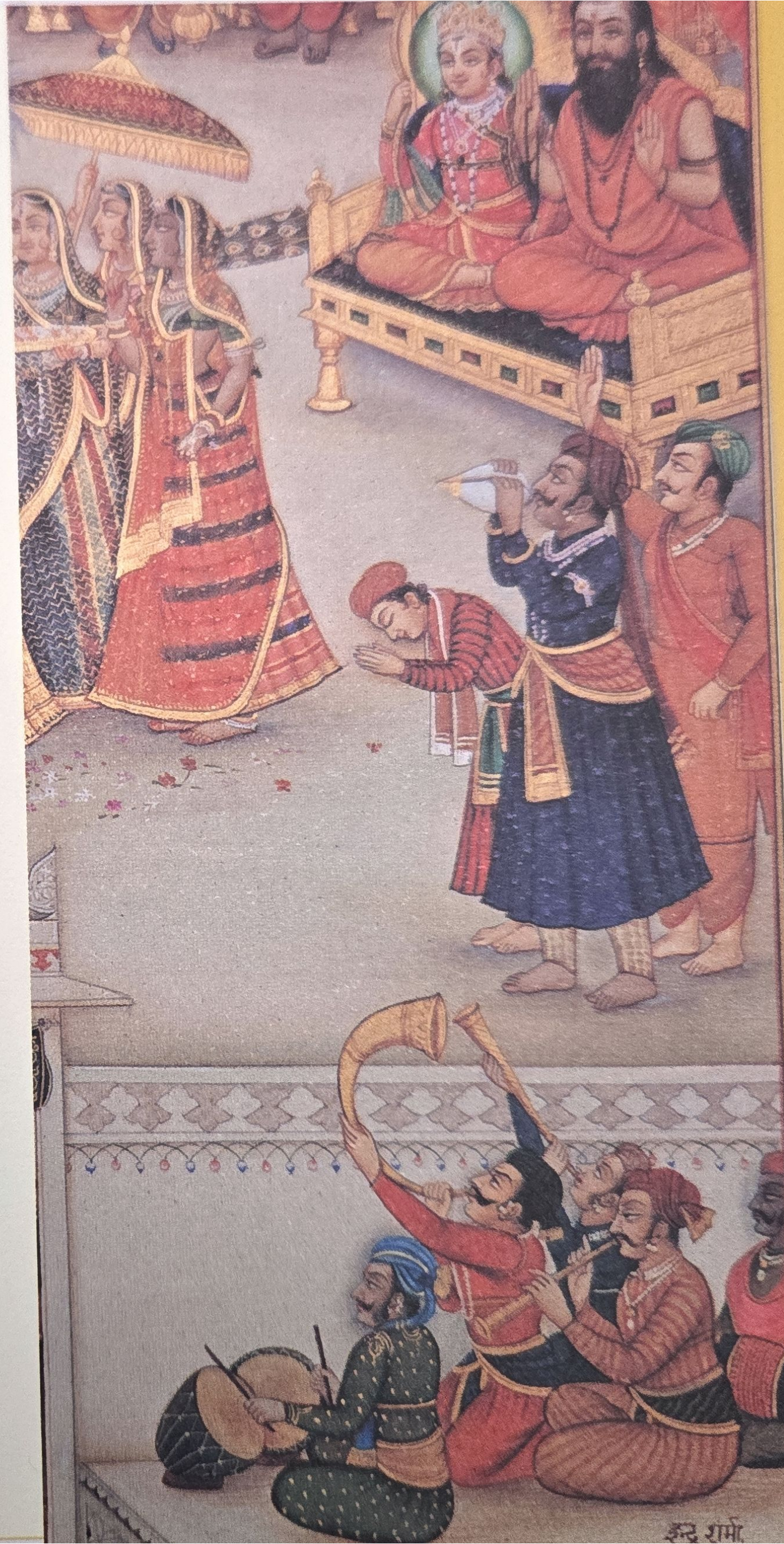
The following tracks are comprised entirely of traditional chants recorded live in temple settings around the world. All recordings are derived from original archives and are not published elsewhere.

Jaya Râdhâ Ramana Hari bol (9:52) and *Maha Mantra* (11:36)
by Bhuta Bhavana

Jaya Râdhâ Mâdhava (6:23)
by Bhuta Bhavana

Jaya Jaya Deva Hare (12:32)
by Krishna Das Babaji

Short Talk on Chanting and Kirtan (8:38)
by Swami B.B. Tirtha, 2002 at Knight Star Studio



Chant the holy name, chant the holy name, chant the holy name of the Lord.
In this age of quarrel and hypocrisy, there is no other way, no other way, no other way to attain spiritual enlightenment.

— from the Brihan-Naradiya

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The Roots of Kirtan *Disc Two*

1. MORNING MAHA MANTRA *Vrindavan Kirtan*

2. RÂDHÂ RAMANA HARIBOL *Bhuta Bhavana*

3. MAHA MANTRA *Bhuta Bhavana*

4. JAYA RÂDHÂ MÂDHAVA *Bhuta Bhavana*

5. JAYA JAYA DEVA HARE *Krishna Das Babaji*

6. SHORT TALK ON KIRTAN *Swami B. B. Tirtha*

7. RÂMA KRISHNA VÂSUDEVA *Swami B. B. Tirtha*

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